Social Studies Syllabus

Grades 1–4

2026–2027

INSTRUCTOR INFORMATION

Instructor	Email	Class Days
Tiffany Young	Tiffany@rivertech.me	Thursday
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COURSE OVERVIEW

The Grades 1–4 Social Studies program helps students understand people, communities, government, geography, history, culture, and economics in an age-appropriate and engaging way.

Students use Polymath Panda Social Studies Workbooks at their grade level. The curriculum introduces social studies through short readings, vocabulary, maps, matching, labeling, written responses, review activities, and practical connections to everyday life.

Students begin by learning about families, schools, communities, rules, responsibilities, maps, and the difference between past and present. As they progress through the grades, they develop a broader understanding of citizenship, government, geography, U.S. history, economics, cultural traditions, regions, timelines, and how people and places are connected.

Verbal discussion is incorporated throughout the course. Students are encouraged to ask questions, explain their thinking, compare communities and cultures, discuss historical events, interpret maps, and make connections between what they are learning and the world around them.

The overall goal is to help students become informed, responsible, and curious citizens who understand their community, country, world, and the people and events that have shaped them.

COURSE MATERIALS

Required Materials

- Polymath Panda Social Studies Workbooks (at the student's grade level)

SYLLABUS

Communities & Culture

Students learn about the people and groups that make up communities. Younger students explore families, neighborhoods, schools, community helpers, rules, traditions, and places in a community. As students progress, they learn how communities may be similar or different and explore customs, traditions, culture, language, celebrations, and ways people live in different places. Students are encouraged to respect differences while recognizing values and responsibilities that help communities function well.

Civics & Government

Students develop an age-appropriate understanding of rules, laws, citizenship, leadership, rights, and responsibilities.

Grade Band	Focus
Grade 1	Classroom and community rules, responsible behavior, helping others, and basic community leadership.
Grade 2	Government and civic life, community responsibilities, rules and laws, citizenship, and the roles people play in a community.
Grades 3–4	A deeper understanding of government, leadership, civic participation, rights and responsibilities, and how citizens contribute to their communities.

Geography & Map Skills

Students develop geographic understanding through maps, globes, directions, symbols, landforms, bodies of water, regions, and location. Younger students learn to recognize simple maps and understand basic location and direction. As students progress, they learn to use map keys and symbols, identify directions, locate continents and oceans, recognize landforms and bodies of water, understand regions and locations, compare places, and interpret increasingly detailed maps.

History

Students learn that history helps us understand people, events, places, and change over time.

Grade Band	Focus
Grade 1	Past and present, family and community history, important people, and simple historical sequencing.
Grade 2	Historical people, events, communities, and beginning timelines.
Grade 3	Historical change, important people and events, communities, regions, and how the past influences the present.
Grade 4	More focused U.S. history, including important people, events, ideas, and timelines, with an emphasis on connecting historical information rather than simply memorizing isolated facts.

Economics

Students develop a basic understanding of how people make choices about resources, goods, services, work, and money. Beginning concepts include needs and wants, goods and services, jobs and community workers, making choices, and buying and selling. As students progress, they begin to understand resources, economic choices, producers and consumers, and how goods and services move through communities.

Grade 1 Social Studies

Grade 1 focuses on students' immediate world. Topics include families and communities, school and classroom rules, responsibilities, community helpers, maps and basic directions, neighborhoods and places, past and present, beginning history, traditions, and culture.

Grade 2 Social Studies

Grade 2 expands students' understanding beyond the immediate classroom and family. Topics include communities and culture, government and civics, geography and history, maps, goods and services, community roles and responsibilities, traditions and cultural differences, and basic economics.

Grade 3 Social Studies

Grade 3 builds broader geographic, civic, historical, and economic understanding. Students increasingly work with communities and regions, maps and globes, continents and oceans, landforms, geography and location, government and citizenship, history and timelines, culture, goods and services, and economic choices. Students begin making stronger connections between people, places, events, and systems.

Grade 4 Social Studies

Grade 4 develops a more detailed understanding of U.S. history, geography and map skills, government, civics and citizenship, rights and responsibilities, economics, communities, culture, historical timelines, important people and events, regions, directions, locations, and symbols.

Vocabulary & Reading

Social Studies instruction also supports literacy. Students learn age-appropriate vocabulary related to history, geography, civics, economics, government, and culture. They read short informational passages, interpret pictures and maps, answer comprehension questions, label diagrams, complete written responses, and discuss what they are learning. As students progress, they are expected to explain ideas increasingly in their own words.

Discussion & Critical Thinking

Verbal discussion is incorporated into Social Studies lessons. Students are encouraged to ask and answer questions, share observations and opinions, compare communities and cultures, explain why rules and laws are important, interpret maps and locations, discuss historical events, consider cause and effect, make connections between past and present, and explain how people contribute to a community. The emphasis is on understanding social studies concepts rather than simply memorizing names and dates.

Practical & Real-World Connections

Teachers connect social studies concepts to students' everyday experiences whenever possible. Students may discuss their own community, identify local services and leaders, use maps, compare traditions, discuss current and historical examples, and connect economic concepts such as goods, services, needs, and wants to familiar situations.

Individualized Learning

Instruction is adjusted according to students' age, reading level, background knowledge, and readiness. Teachers may read passages aloud, simplify explanations, provide additional maps or visuals, expand discussion, or offer more advanced work when appropriate. The focus is on helping students develop a meaningful understanding of people, places, communities, history, and citizenship rather than simply completing workbook pages.

COURSE GOALS

By the end of the elementary Social Studies program, students will demonstrate continued growth in geography, map skills, history, civics, government, economics, culture, vocabulary, critical thinking, and communication.

Students will increasingly be able to understand maps, explain how communities function, recognize basic principles of citizenship and government, describe how people and places change over time, understand foundational U.S. history, and thoughtfully discuss the world around them.